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Skills describe the workflow. Tools do the repeated work.

A practical mental model for coding agents.

A skill can be markdown

It tells the agent when to use a file-system pipeline, a REST API pipeline, debugging steps, or data validation steps.

A tool is executable

It reads files, counts rows, queries tables, runs pipelines, and inspects schemas through deterministic code.

Why this matters

The model can plan and choose the right workflow. Reusable code handles the operations that should not be invented every time.

In the workshop

The dlt workbench routed the agent to the right pipeline toolkit, then tools handled reading, loading, debugging, and validation.

Watch the workshop

A concrete example of skills and tools in an AI engineering workflow.